



Designing an experiential scenario: *The People Who Vanished*



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ABSTRACT

As futures practice strives towards greater effectiveness, the foresight and design fields are in the process of discovering, learning from and remixing with each other. This paper offers a case study of an experiential futures/design fiction project co-created with workshop participants at the inaugural *Emerge* festival, an explicitly futures-themed hybrid arts and science event staged at Arizona State University in the city of Phoenix in 2012. *The People Who Vanished* was a live intervention, via performance and associated artifacts created for the occasion, reflecting on a possible future for the Phoenix area. The workshop's compressed timeline prompted the authors to create for participants a basic framework for producing experiential scenarios. That framework, further elaborated here as the Experiential Futures Ladder, is offered as a conceptual model for scaffolding experiential scenarios and design fiction going forward. Some implications for the foresight field of this multi-scalar mode of thought, as well as of the experiential turn more broadly (towards design, media, games and performance) are outlined.

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1. Introduction

"The great problem of our age," writes [de Jouvenel \(1967\)](#) in his classic futures work *The Art of Conjecture*, "is that we want things to change more rapidly and at the same time we want to have a better knowledge of things to come" (p. 45). The foresight field lives in this paradox.

For at least half a century, we motley few have sought both to document and to influence (if not always accelerate) change, and efforts to do both things more effectively have lately led some among us on this restless quest to acknowledge and start properly mapping previously neglected frontiers of exploration: how foresight can be amplified via design, media, games, and performance. From one angle, this is merely another facet of an inherently transdisciplinary tradition – for futures, of course, all subject matter is fair game because 'the future' contains everything that hasn't happened yet – but from another angle, it is an overdue dialogue with what for many futurists had long been under-investigated modes of thought, expression, and knowledge.

Over the past decade, futures and design in particular have grown into a more intimate and collaborative relationship. Designers are becoming more futures-aware, integrating long-term thinking, scenarios, and other foresight tools into their work. And increasingly futurists are not just studying possibilities from a safe analytical distance, but have become involved in prototyping, and staging futures experiences that use design, while also setting a context for it.

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This article provides a detailed account of one such effort, an experiential futures project staged by the authors, together with a diverse group of collaborators convened for the occasion. The project was called *The People Who Vanished*. This case study is offered partly because hybrid design/futures practitioners too seldom document and share their process as fully as they might, whether due to time pressures or perhaps due to preferring that the work “speak for itself”, but at any rate leaving off the record many of their intellectual and creative options, choices, and rationales.

This article seeks to elucidate why these hybrids matter, and how co-creative processes and frameworks for designing experiential scenarios, such as that detailed here, could yield further results for imagining and manifesting better futures.

2. The emergence of experiential futures

In the past decade or so a love affair between futures and design has blossomed (Candy, 2009).

This much is apparent in the number of self-described futurists affiliated with design organisations and initiatives (the present authors included; as well as Emily Empel, Cindy Frewen, Trevor Haldenby, Noah Rafood, Scott Smith, and Alex Steffen, to name a few examples), and designers doing explicitly futures-type things (including The Extrapolation Factory, Tony Fry, Cher Potter, Superflux, Jason Tester, and Liam Young, among many others). Such hybrid activity may also be found in the programming of organisations like the Association of Professional Futurists (2009 Gathering theme, “Futures by Design”), the Oxford Futures Forum (2014 theme, “Design and Scenarios”), and Arizona State University’s annual *Emerge* conference, starting in 2012, which sports the tagline “Artists and Scientists Redesign the Future”. It shows in the emergence of academic programs at the intersection of foresight and design: Ontario College of Art and Design (OCAD) University’s MDes in Strategic Foresight and Innovation starting in 2009, California College of the Arts (CCA) Design MBA in Strategic Foresight (SFMBA) opening in 2014, and Royal Melbourne Institute of Technology (RMIT) University’s MA in Design Futures launching in 2015. And not least, it can be seen in the development throughout of a thematically wide-ranging, yet creatively and intellectually distinctive, current of practice and discourse, to date most fully documented in Candy’s (2010) *The Futures of Everyday Life* and Dunne and Raby’s (2013) *Speculative Everything*.

Several terms have been associated with these developments, including “design fiction”, “speculative design” or “speculative and critical design” (SCD), and “experiential futures”.

Experiential futures evolved from the collaboration of the present authors, beginning in 2006 (simultaneously with the dawn of design fiction, as it turned out). The practice originated with a need and opportunity that we identified, to engage people more viscerally in futures conversations, which typically had high stakes but low affective engagement and embodied insight. The need for experiential futures is rooted in a challenge inherent to futures work: by definition, it deals with abstractions. (If, as most futurists seem to agree, the future does not exist, this is a straightforward observation about the subject matter rather than a criticism.) In order to activate adequate consideration and responses, then, “the future” (or indeed the futures field) needs all the help it can get.¹ As Candy (2010) has written:

[A]n experiential scenario is the manifestation of one or more fragments of an ostensible future world in any medium or combination of media including image, artifact, and performance. It involves designing and staging interventions that exploit the continuum of human experience, the full array of sensory and semiotic vectors, in order to enable a different and deeper engagement in thought and discussion about one or more futures, than has traditionally been possible through textual and statistical means of representing scenarios (Candy, 2010; p. 3).

This remains the principal motivation and rationale for experiential futures. It is about doing futures work – exploring and shaping change – more effectively, by using “the continuum of human experience”, instead of confining activity to legacy methods and media, such as white papers, or workshops relying entirely on verbal exchange. For futures to find its way into the mainstream of culture, and thereby contribute to the development of a cultural-level “social foresight” (Slaughter, 1996), Candy has argued that we must bridge the “experiential gulf” between inherently abstract notions of possible futures, and life as it is apprehended, felt, embedded and embodied in the present and on the ground.

Experiential futures (and its companion experiential scenarios²) was selected as a master concept in Candy’s (2010) doctoral work from among a number of other early contenders, including tangible futures, immersive futures, immersive scenarios, and so on, because both the challenge and opportunity described above transcend particular choices of media and manner of deployment. A more recent formulation of experiential futures practice; “the design of situations and stuff from the future to catalyse insight and change”.³ The term, and more to the point, the activity itself, has a deliberately wide compass. It includes not only futures-inflected editions of conventional design outputs (print material, concept images, prototypes, physical artifacts, etc), but also takes in all manner of other things that one might create in order to manifest, evoke and make available thoughts, feelings and insights about the whole gamut of possible futures. This wide palette includes installation, mail art, advertisements, immersive theatre, guerrilla intervention, digital simulation (VR/MR/AR), and games. Tangible, immersive, interactive, live, and playable modes are all in scope.

¹ This case is set out at length in Candy, 2010; Chapter 2.

² The terms experiential futures and experiential scenarios are not interchangeable, but differ by analogy with their original counterparts. *Futures* as umbrella for the practice; *scenarios* as output of a particular method, naturally with a great many potential variations in technique to generate them. See Candy, 2010; p. 3.

³ Candy (2015) a parallel to Sterling’s short “design fiction” definition.

Meanwhile, *Design fiction* emerged over this same ten-year period, from the intersection of design and speculative storytelling (Bleecker, 2009; Sterling, 2009). Originally proposed by designer Julian Bleecker, he later wrote:

Design fiction . . . is a conflation of design, science fact, and science fiction. It is [an] amalgamation of practices [and] a way of materializing ideas and speculations without the pragmatic curtailing that often happens when dead weights are fastened to the imagination (Bleecker, 2009, p.6).

Bleecker applied the term not only to projects carried out prospectively with this specific form of exploration in mind, but also retroactively, citing certain classic sci-fi movie props as design fiction *avant la lettre* (e.g. painstakingly researched space travel technologies depicted in *2001: A Space Odyssey*, and the gestural interface shown in *Minority Report*). In the past six or seven years, design fiction has come to enjoy a certain mainstream currency in the design world, in no small part due to the efforts of science fiction author Bruce Sterling, who has also offered a concise definition: “the deliberate use of diegetic prototypes to suspend disbelief about change” (Sterling, 2013).

The practice of design fiction, broadly speaking, seeks to manifest possible worlds tangibly, although not always set in the future – see for instance Pohflepp’s (2009) counterfactual “The Golden Institute” – most often through physical objects and installations, or media artifacts such as short films. Overlapping significantly with the recently popular frame “speculative design”, other examples include “Bug-out bags” by Parsons and Charlesworth (n.d.) the TBD Catalog from Near Future Laboratory (New Future Laboratory, n.d.) and, even if it was not specifically created under this banner, the *New York Times Special Edition* by Steve Lambert and the Yes Men (Lambert, n.d.). The recent card game *The Thing From The Future*, co-designed by Stuart Candy and Jeff Watson, has been described by its creators as a “design fiction game” because the original version is a combinatorial engine for creating millions of possible prompts to generate ideas for future cultural artifacts; mostly tangible (Device, Jewellery, Building), some not (Headline, Ritual, Company) (Candy, 2015).

Design fiction, then, uses the materiality and idioms of graphic, interaction, and product design, and frequently video, to prototype elements of a possible world; past, present or future.

The authors of this paper have been closely involved in these developments over the past decade. Our own explorations in bringing futures to life began with informal conversations in the mid-2000s with colleagues including Jose Ramos and Wendy Schultz about the need and potential for futures to diversify and deepen its relationships with storytelling, performance, media and design. Meeting as graduate students at the University of Hawaii at Manoa futures program in 2005, we found ourselves well placed to embark on applied investigation of that potential. This began with the *Hawaii 2050* project in 2006 (Cascio, 2006); carried on to the first *Foundfutures* guerrilla interventions the next year (Griffith, 2007; Goldberg, 2007; Wu, 2007); a live performance of a possible future for copyright at South by Southwest (SXSW) in 2008 (Candy, 2008); the alternate reality game *Coral Cross* for the Hawaii Department of Health and US CDC in 2009 (Pescovitz, 2009), Candy’s stint as visiting lecturer with Dunne, Raby and students at the Royal College of Art (RCA) in 2009 (Dunne, 2010), and both of us speaking on Design Fiction at SXSW in 2010, together with Sterling, Bleecker, and RCA alumnus Pohflepp (Bleecker et al., 2010). This panel was later described by the science fiction author as “the ground zero of design fiction” (Sterling, 2011).

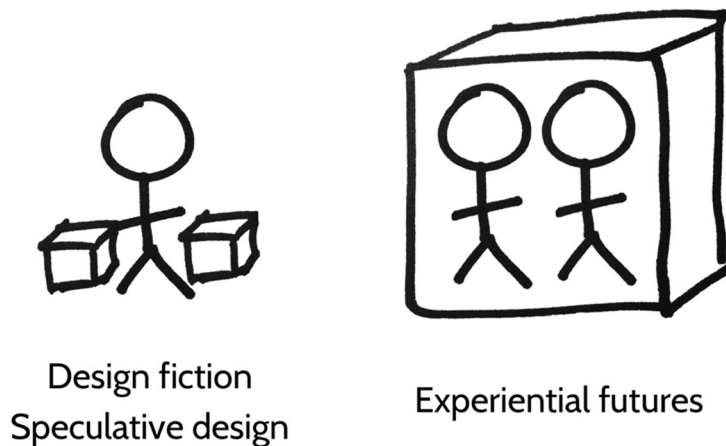
In these contexts and others since, we have executed and advised on a wide variety of experiential scenarios from immersive alternative futures for a group of 550 people at a public policy-oriented sustainability event, to guerrilla street art campaigns. Partnering organisations have included local, state, and national governments, community groups, educational institutions, museums, private enterprises, and nonprofits. The exploration of ways to materialise, perform, and evoke alternative futures in order to catalyse new insight and action continues, particularly through the classes we teach at the world’s first two foresight programs offered at design schools, at OCAD and CCA.

We observe that experiential futures and design fiction (etc) are very much intertwined, and despite originating independently with futurists on one hand, and designers on the other, the similarities between them as hybrid design/futures practices are more important than the differences. Both are lenses through which previously mostly-parallel practices and discourses have been able to discover, access, and intertwine with the other, offering an invitation or alibi of sorts to borrow from and experiment with new tools, or blur the lines between them altogether. The adoption of the futurist’s ‘cone of possibilities’ in the design world since its introduction to students at the Royal College of Art in 2009 is one example (Dunne & Raby, 2013, p. 3–5; Nesta, 2016).

We do not intend here to offer a detailed critique of terminology as others have recently done (Thackara, 2013; Prado & Oliveira, 2014; Tonkinwise, 2015), but in the evolution of these practices one can discern traces of their respective origins and framing. The notions of design fiction and speculative design enjoy wider currency (as does design relative to futures discourse), and they have a tendency towards expression in physical objects, in line with design’s customary beat in material artifacts. Experiential futures, like futures generally, is less common, but is inherently transmedial in form, declaring all experience to be fair game, rather than defaulting to tangible objects (or films about products/artifacts), as the preferred medium, which design fiction and speculative design often do.

The breadth of experiential futures as a design space makes it a suitable conceptual and generative container for those less concerned with particular media or arts traditions than with catalysing high-quality engagement, insight, and action to shape change, using whatever means fit the situation. For our purposes the range of ways in which one can create a context for thinking and feeling future possibilities, for individuals and groups alike, is a more accommodating and relevant canvas than the design space of future artifacts alone. This line of thought can be developed more fully elsewhere, but it may be that the frames of design fiction and speculative design (and attendant concerns in some quarters as to what “counts” as design,

etc) play some part in slowing down development of performative and immersive registers of futures work.⁴ The wider canvas of options for making futures ideas into experiences holds great promise, in our view, as a design space for the upcoming generation of practitioners to continue to discover and map.



[Figure by Stuart Candy, with thanks to Greg Van Alstyne]

Part of what's at stake in this exploration process in its many variations is that experiential futures work does not always leave a documentary trail. Thus, an opportunity for scholarly work in this area at this point in its development lies in collecting and describing cases for the field to build on (Kelliher & Byrne, 2015).

The case study shared here documents the creation of an experiential scenario closely informed by local conditions, while also tied to more “universal” human challenges through parallels in other times and places. It is hoped this will be informative both to those with an intellectual interest in experiential futures, and to those practising in the space.

A further step beyond such documentation, now coming into its own, is the need for models recording and demonstrating the impacts of these projects on those involved. That next step is not the focus of this paper, which deals with the co-creation process itself, but as the practice matures, the time is coming for experiential futures work to add more systematic evaluation approaches to the toolkit, too.⁵

3. In search of an ‘archaeological moment’

On 1–3 March 2012, scores of scientists, artists, writers, futurists, students, and designers gathered at Arizona State University (ASU) in Phoenix for *Emerge: Artists and Scientists Redesign the Future*. This academic summit and series of workshops was hosted by ASU to explore alternative visions for humanity by bringing them to life through design and performance. Initiated by futurists Bruce Sterling and Joel Garreau, the event was a milestone in the development of the practice of experiential futures and design fiction—a sign of their progression from the fringes of design and futures studies towards a more central place in both (Bosch, 2012; Selin, 2015).

Our workshop was one of nine concurrent sessions occurring across campus, (Arizona State University, n.d.) and the task was to take 16 experiential futures novices – artists, performers, anthropologists, students, and others – and induct them into the practice by conceiving, developing, and executing an experiential scenario in two and a half days. This meant we would ultimately stage some sort of material installation, video, performance, or event on the Saturday morning in front of a large public audience at ASU's Neeb Hall, but within those constraints, we could basically do whatever we wished.

As it turned out, in the course of this workshop a startling “archaeological discovery” was made – one with far-reaching implications for the future of Phoenix and its inhabitants.⁶

Considering Phoenix's notoriety as one of the “least sustainable places in America” (Ross, 2011), it offered no shortage of futures-related issues to which we could yoke the design process. However, we also recognised that presumptuous questions from outsiders – such as, “do you know you have a water problem?” – might not put things on a productive footing. So we

⁴ See for example the article from UK innovation organisation, Nesta (2016).

⁵ For his culminating project in OCAD University's foresight program, MDes student Michael Stulberg used a qualitative research method called Interpretive Phenomenological Analysis (IPA) to document and theorise the impacts on participants of several experiential scenarios created by fellow students in the program: M. Stulberg (forthcoming), 2016, “Excavating Our Futures: Exploring Participation in Experiential Scenarios.” OCAD University Strategic Foresight and Innovation.

⁶ A video of the presentation/performance can be found here: <https://vimeo.com/39659785>.

sought to address critical issues facing the Valley of the Sun in a more intellectually oblique, but also experientially direct, fashion. For this project, we did not start with the future, or even the present. We took a deep dive into the past.

The name Phoenix invokes the bird of Greek myth which would periodically burn up and rise again from its own ashes. It is a striking but little known fact that the city was so named precisely because it was built atop the ruins of a lost civilisation (*City of Phoenix, n.d.*). Beneath the streets and sidewalks of today's Phoenix of four million inhabitants lie the remnants of the Hohokam (*Arizona Museum of Natural History, n.d.*), a society which flourished from around 0CE to 1400CE; "from Christ to Columbus". The Hohokam were expert canal engineers and irrigation agriculturalists. They built a thriving civilisation in the desert lasting almost one and a half millennia. They farmed the land and channeled water through massive canals without any of the modern tools and equipment we have today (*Abbott, 2003*). However, about a century before the arrival of Europeans in North America, they suddenly disappeared, for reasons that are unknown, and that are still debated by archaeologists.

The name Hohokam is an O'odham word meaning "the people who vanished" (*Mays & Gorokhovich, 2010*). Being an oral culture, it is unknown what they called themselves. So a question which we hoped to evoke for participants at *Emerge* became: "could the people of today's Phoenix be the next to vanish from the valley?"

In order to push the boundaries of experiential futures, to do justice to the scope of the historical (and future) questions at hand, and to create a unique and fun learning experience for our workshop participants, we were drawn to the idea of executing a project at a monumental scale. We wanted to create something big; something that demanded attention; something that would appear suddenly and without warning – and that could carry deep meaning for the attendees. In our practice we and others often create hypothetical "artifacts from the future",⁷ but in this case thought it could be interesting to create a fictional artifact from the past, in order to enable a re-perception of present and future.⁸ It may be unnecessary to point out how this was a departure from the usual preoccupation with the future per se in futures and experiential futures work, yet it also ties to a basic, if often overlooked, idea in the foresight field; that any alternative future entails or corresponds to an imaginary taking in the entire chronology. This is why history is and must be constantly rethought and rewritten, instead of simply accreting like so many layers of sediment: new developments in the present simultaneously change our living relationship to both future and past.

Throughout history, there have been breakthrough moments when we humans have been forced to confront our own ignorance and reimagine our collective story about who we are and where we came from. The unearthing of dinosaur fossils revealed a strange and diverse lifeworld on Earth long before human existence, overturning earlier thinking about natural history. Similarly disruptive were cultural discoveries such as the Dead Sea Scrolls, the Rosetta Stone, the city of Pompeii, and ancient technologies such as the Antikythera machine. The rediscovery of ancient philosophy, architecture, or artifacts from time to time has not merely added to a trove of curiosities from the past; but has changed society's self-understanding. The Renaissance, the Enlightenment, and other epochal transitions have been initiated or accelerated by such archaeological moments.

There are always bound to be, this line of thinking suggests, possibility grenades beneath our feet, primed to explode our fragile certainties and platitudes about the story of our world. As U.S. President Harry Truman once said, "The only thing new in the world is the history you don't know."⁹

What could this "new" and transformative – albeit hypothetical – slice of history be for Phoenix?

In order to ground thinking about possible archaeological moments appropriate to the Valley of the Sun, early investigation included reading about the prehistory of the area (*Reisner, 1987; Debuys, 2011*), and speaking with Dr. David Abbott of the human evolution and social change program at ASU. In this emerging dance of fact and fiction, local and non-local, our exploration also drew inspiration from film and other media. The mysterious monolith from the movie *2001: A Space Odyssey* (*Kubrick, 1968*), as well as the underground Martian technology from *Total Recall* (*Verhoeven, 1990*) both provided a reference points for the disorienting and transformative quality we would seek to evoke with participants. The latter story, featuring an ancient and enormous underground machine with the capacity to reproduce an Earthlike atmosphere on Mars, echoes contemporary media debates around geoengineering. This is the (for now) largely speculative, and highly controversial, idea of using direct measures to slow or mitigate global warming by turning climate "dials" in the right directions. Geoengineering techniques include adding iron filings to the ocean to create algae blooms sequestering CO₂, deploying cloud-brightening additives to reflect more sunlight and cool the Earth, or adding materials to the atmosphere to diffuse sunlight (*Cascio, 2009*). As the Hohokam had been expert engineers, and appeared to have faced persistent climate and resource challenges around the time of their disappearance, we began to imagine how these ancient peoples may have attempted a kind of "paleo-geoengineering" in a desperate attempt to sustain their civilisation. The Hohokam response to the resource depletion and climate change might also be informative for understanding how we could deal with those issues today, in the so-called Anthropocene, a geological epoch defined by human influence on planetary systems (*Steffen, Crutzen, & McNeill, 2007*).

With these big issues motivating the engagement, and with the archaeological moment as a narrative target, our next challenge would be how to translate these directions into a form that could be communicated on a monumental (or

⁷ The term comes from the long-running, now defunct monthly back page feature of *Wired* magazine. See *Candy (2010, p. 190, note 404)*.

⁸ The term "re-perception" is used here in tribute to the pioneering scenario planner Pierre Wack, who described scenarios work as being about 'the gentle art of re-perceiving' (*Wack, 1985; p. 147*).

⁹ As quoted in <http://www.archives.gov/publications/prologue/2009/spring/truman-history.html>.

seemingly monumental) scale? In the leadup to the event we surmised, for instance, that it might be feasible to bury a mysterious object ahead of time for participants to dig up, and then have them try to work out what it meant. Also considered was the option of co-creating such an artifact during the workshop, then recording its momentous discovery via live video feed to the auditorium audience. Maybe it would even be possible to secure the cooperation of a local TV news crew.

In any case the key design questions remained: What ‘find’ could the workshop produce to elicit the feeling of a Rosetta Stone-scale impact? What kind of experiential scenario might we develop with participants to simulate an “archaeological moment” for those who would see our performance? And how could all of this be achieved with under 14 h of actual workshop time?

4. Designing a design process

Co-creative and participatory processes come in many shapes and forms, influenced by the values and goals of participants, as well as by the idiosyncratic constraints and affordances of each situation.¹⁰ In order to co-produce an experiential scenario this rapidly – an order of magnitude faster than had been available for our previous projects on a similar scale of deployment – it was necessary to think carefully about which elements of the plan would need to be predetermined, and which should be left open, in order to give the group’s explorations the necessary balance of fixity and wiggle room. In terms of both production output and pedagogical design, this was something of a tightrope act. With too many elements stipulated in advance; say we had walked in with a script and tried to get 16 people we’d never met before to make “our” film (at one point we contemplated animating the paleoengineering premise through a sort of *Chariots of the Gods*-style mockumentary), then some might reasonably object to being co-opted as workhorses into a not-so-creative process, where the most interesting questions had been pre-empted. On the other hand, with so little time available, to begin without a robust framework for co-creation could easily get us caught in a preliminary and conceptual no-man’s-land, leaving too little time for actually making something together.

To strike the right balance between fixed structure and set content on the one hand, and free-range creative exploration on the other, is a crucial consideration in futures pedagogy and workshops. How do you choreograph things so that the right amount of material is provided and the learning process effectively scaffolded, with as little fat on it as possible? Too prepopulated can be stultifying; but too open can be confusing and inefficient, a recipe for wasting precious cognitive and creative cycles. The same can be said of any group co-creative process, and it would be interesting to consider existing workshops and their component phases (such as the GBN eight step scenario creation process (Schwartz, 1991; p. 241–247) in terms of how they scaffold and harnesses people’s collective attention to navigate between dauntingly open-ended or unwittingly foreclosed design space.

In the event, things ran as follows.

In advance, beginning around 6 months ahead, we:

- Identified and researched the subject of interest (the Hohokam disappearance, and the potential resonance of that episode with the situation of early 21st century Phoenicians).
- Decided on a ‘feel’ for the offering we would seek to create; i.e., the ‘monumental artifact’ and the ‘archaeological moment’, with some genre, aesthetic and conceptual reference points.
- Made the best inventory we could, from a distance, of the resources that could be brought to bear during the workshop period (e.g., enlisting the support of a gracious *Emerge* volunteer to scout and secure permission to dig up a credible ‘set’ for our archaeological find).

In the workshop, we:

- Introduced ourselves as facilitators and creators of experiential scenarios, and showed highlights of our previous work, with critical commentary.
- Brought people up to speed with our thinking on the topic so far, and began to generate excitement and intrigue around the subject and its narrative possibilities. (To be more precise: the *kind* of scenario, or general *Setting* was preset; namely the link between Phoenix’s prehistory, its present and its future. For the specific story or *Scenario*, we articulated a starting point or “seed”, but no specifics, despite having the “paleoengineering” concept in our back pocket.) This part of the workshop included a wonderful guest speaker, Dr. Jerry Howard, curator of anthropology at the Arizona Museum of Natural History. Dr. Howard, an expert in Hohokam archaeology, provided a fine account of the history, culture, and artifacts of the Hohokam.

¹⁰ What is important to note in the litany of narrative and design choices described here is how at each decision point, an array of possible worlds are immediately rendered non-existent. Each iterative movement towards a concrete plan calls new worlds and possibilities into being, while altering or occluding others. This is of course part of any creative act, but the political stakes are more pronounced for experiential futures because the futures imaginary is a place of collaborative construction of possible futures. Experiential futures create encounters with other worlds, and while all possible futures can never be known, practitioners must be mindful of what other possible worlds are being disowned or left behind in the process. One way to address this challenge is to design participatory processes for maximising diversity and inclusivity of ideas considered.

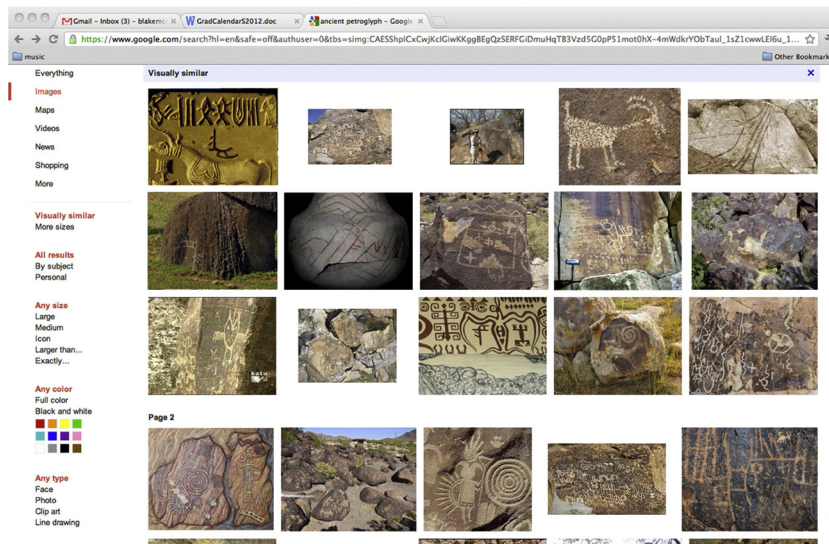


[Image – a mysterious symbol embedded in the Hohokam canal system (diegetic)]

Once this was highlighted, there was little difficulty in weaving a story around the image, and investing it with symbolic significance. This, after all, is part of what human minds are made to do. It's how symbols work.

In short order, then, we realised that the Saturday morning presentation could tell the following story:

In puzzling out the fate of the Hohokam, our group had spotted this curious anomaly on the map (so far, entirely true), and had then been inspired by the thought of a symbolic, and not merely functional, role for the canals (also true). One of our number then had the idea to do a google image search for this pattern and see what turned up (still true – sort of – although maybe the biggest logical stretch). Shockingly, this search showed up a range of other instances of the same 'glyph' in diverse archaeological records elsewhere: the Harappan of the Indus Valley, the Anasazi, the Nazca, the Polynesian peoples of Rapa Nui, aka Easter Island. All this part was of course completely simulated; photoshopped into found photographs from these places. (See figures TK-TK.¹¹) We would also be able to show how the glyph had turned up subtly but unmistakably, inscribed in the patterns on Hohokam pottery too. And the kicker: the sole common characteristic discernible across all these disparate cultures, from wildly different eras and geographies, was that they had all disappeared. They were all collapsed civilisations.¹²



[Image: Google image search results revealing appearances of the glyph in various times and places (diegetic)]

¹¹ Borrowing a useful convention from live action roleplaying (larp) scholarship, images shown here that were "from" the experiential scenario diegesis are marked "diegetic".

¹² Among the most influential works on collapsed civilisations are Diamond (2005) and Tainter (1988).



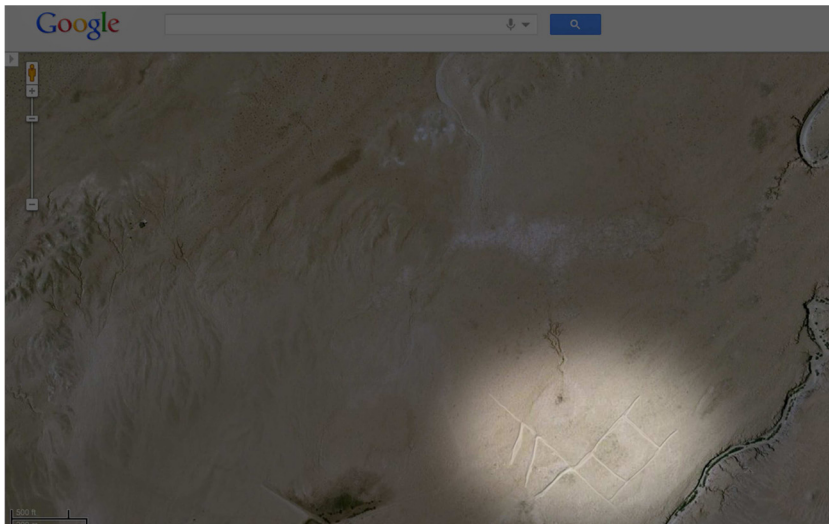
[Image – Hohokam pottery (diegetic)]



[Image – Harappan artwork from the Indus Valley, today Pakistan (diegetic)]



[Image – Anasazi drawings from the Southwest of present-day USA (diegetic)]



[Image – Nazca lines, Peru (diegetic)]



[Image – the collapse glyph appears in the archaeological record of Rapa Nui (Easter Island) (diegetic)]

The rest was conceptually straightforward, if logistically demanding in the time available. We already had the basic shape of the Situation in which this story would be told – a live presentation from the stage on Saturday morning. Now the details fell into place. Our group would create what looked like real, but previously unnoticed or unconnected, instances of the glyph appearing in these various contexts. We counted on search-by-image being a comparatively recent and little-used search option, and with the astonishing potency and rapid progress of these tools, those factors together might make it reasonable to the audience that our little workshop gathering could really have stumbled upon something that had so far escaped archaeologists. An acceptable invitation to invest belief was the thing; we weren't aiming to fool everyone, or to carry it on indefinitely – the Rapa Nui image [figure X] would surely signal the joke to any audience members who hadn't clued in by that stage. But, for those who 'wanted to believe,' there was just enough plausibility to hang on to.

Once this scenario "container" for the experience had been articulated, it was easy to extend the list of ways in which it might be made manifest. A few participants eagerly mounted a covert operation to install the glyph in large outline atop Tempe Butte, also known as 'A' Mountain, visible from the mall on campus outside Neeb Hall.

On Saturday, immediately following the group's presentation about this transcultural "discovery" was the lunch break. The audience, having just seen this ominous symbol appearing in diverse cultures around the world shortly before they disappeared, adjourned into the open air and caught sight of the same glyph on the mountain overlooking the campus. The circuit of this experiential scenario was complete.



[Photo - the glyph on Tempe Butte, aka "A" Mountain]

In total, then, this experience, and more particularly, the symbol at its centre, had three touchpoints with the audience. The first was the presentation recounting the group's amazing 'discovery'. The second was the monumental glyph appearing on the hillside just afterward, reinforcing the symbol and carrying it on outside the immediate context of the *Emerge* reports. The third was the surprise illumination of the glyph on the campus art museum that night.¹³



[Photoillustration – the same glyph built into ASU's Nelson Fine Arts Center]

¹³ During production period on Friday, with teams of people running around creating and organising elements of the installation, a truly eerie moment occurred: one of the participants realised that the Nelson Fine Arts Center across campus, where *Emerge*'s closing festivities would play out the following evening, *actually had the outline of the glyph built into its architecture*. We felt compelled to incorporate this into the culmination of the presentation the next day. This part of the story, then, about the appearance of the glyph in the campus architecture, and the mention of architect Antoine Predock drawing inspiration for the design from disappeared civilisations and 'alien' iconography, was entirely (if bizarrely) true. (Personal communication with ASU Art Museum director Gordon Knox, who happened to join our workshop that afternoon, 2 March 2012.) The group did take the liberty of photoshopping a small adjustment to the original canal map in order to perfect the resemblance, but the basic potential here for amplifying and extending the experiential scenario into the evening was irresistible. A subset of the production team then took it upon themselves to clamber over 30 feet up on to the museum structure on Saturday morning and outline the glyph with a string of LEDs so that the symbolic encounter could be reactivated during the evening performances to be held that night, serendipitously, just outside the museum.



[Photo - the glyph, highlighted]

Such was the 'monumental' experiential scenario of *The People Who Vanished*. It combined a novel technique (the creation of an archaeological moment) with an issue of local concern (a desert community living at the edge of sustainability), and was executed via a team of experiential futures novices in under three days using a collaborative and participatory process.

The next section reflects on the process described, drawing out some implications for foresight practice in general, and experiential futures in particular.

5. The Experiential Futures Ladder

One cannot in real time discern a flower opening and closing over the course of a day, the 'explosion' of cloudbursts before a storm, or forests as they change colors through the seasons. Much as timelapse photography brings these 'slow' processes into a more human-observable timeframe, the compressed timeline of *Emerge* brought new clarity to the arc of our design process – birthing what we found to be a simple and useful framework for experiential scenario production.

As described already, the group was oriented into its collective task with three givens, or 'fixed' elements, as backdrop. One was that the *Setting* (or subject) of the narrative would relate somehow to Phoenix's prehistory and the mysterious disappearance of the Hohokam just before the Columbian/colonial era. The second was that we would seek to tell a story or *Scenario* through an 'archaeological moment' concerning some kind of monumental discovery. The third element, more or less predetermined by the structure of the *Emerge* event, was the actual *Situation* in which this narrative would meet its primary audience; a fifteen minute timeslot onstage at the ASU campus, on Saturday morning. Here, then, was a kind of three-rung 'ladder of abstraction'¹⁴ that could be used to navigate and toggle between our broad conceptual commitments and concrete narrative and design options:

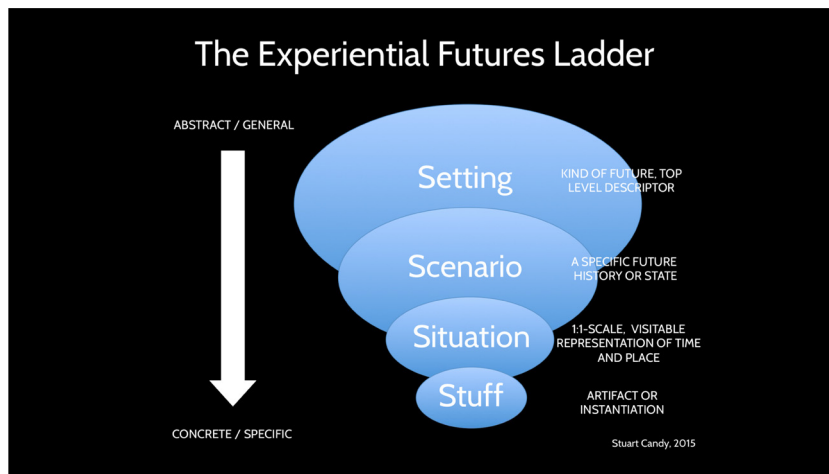
SETTING: The theme or kind of future (e.g. generic image of the future).

SCENARIO: Specific narrative proposition and sequence of events.

SITUATION: The circumstances of encounter; particular events given physical form at 1:1 scale in various media.

We used these layers to orient participants to the elements of the process that were already fixed (location/setting, broad theme, timing), and why. The layers also helped us make apparent which elements were still open and so needed collective attention and definition. The fact that the group was able to accomplish its work in so short a timespan suggested that the framework could prove useful elsewhere too.

¹⁴ The phrase "ladder of abstraction" is borrowed from the work of linguist S.I. Hayakawa. It appears in his 1939 book *Language in Thought and Action*.



[Diagram by Stuart Candy]

In the time since this first case, we have elaborated the Experiential Futures Ladder (adding “Stuff” – particular artifacts – at the bottom¹⁵), and continued to use and develop the framework through strategic foresight classes taught by Dunagan at CCA and Candy at OCAD University.

We have also used this framework in the inaugural “Design Futures Master Class,” run at the Monterrey Center for Higher Learning of Design (CEDIM) in Mexico City in June 2015. This was among the most compressed co-creation processes to date, with a range of immersive and participatory experiential scenarios lasting 20 minutes being generated by groups of 3–5 people in under 48 hours.¹⁶

This iterative movement towards concrete detail in an experiential scenario may be clarified via a parallel in filmmaking.

A narrative feature film typically goes through a lengthy development process involving an outline early on, then a treatment outlining the setting and the story and characters within it. This is then fleshed out as a screenplay with dialogue etc. Well before the first second of film has been shot, from these documents the designers of sets, props and costumes work out what physical elements of the movie world must be found or created in order to bring the vision to life. Outline, treatment, and screenplay, then, are increasingly detailed expressions of the world in which a film is set and what happens in it. The final translation of written scenes into actors’ performances, together with the tangible paraphernalia completing the simulation, concludes the process. Overall it proceeds from high-level, abstract story elements down to the nitty gritty of 1:1-scale, real-time storytelling.

This climb down from the clouds of narrative concept to the ground of experience can usefully be understood as a particular instance of a more general notion, which science writer Steven Johnson has memorably dubbed “the long zoom”. Johnson goes so far as to identify this movement across scales as a characteristic mode of thought in our age:

the satellites tracking in on license-plate numbers in the spy movies; the Google maps in which a few clicks take you from a view of an entire region to the roof of your house; the opening shot in “Fight Club” that pulls out from Edward Norton’s synapses all the way to his quivering face as he stares into the muzzle of a revolver; the fractal geometry of chaos theory in which each new scale reveals endless complexity. And this is not just a way of seeing but also a way of thinking: moving conceptually from the scale of DNA to the scale of personality all the way up to social movements and politics – and back again (Johnson, 2006).

The long zoom usefully evokes the way we must move from systems thinking at a grand scale, to the detailed minutiae and marginalia that make up lived experience.¹⁷ But experiential futures differs significantly in that it does not merely bring into focus existing objects or processes at different scales, *it brings into being different worlds as our attention comes to them*. In futures, then, attention is not merely an act of interpretation, it is an act of creation. Now experiential futures begins to resemble the Daoists’ description of way-making as a mutually entailing co-creation of person and world. The path does not exist for us to find and navigate, it is created in the walking. In futures, an ever-expanding field of possibility space lies before us, and to understand this space we must engage with it, provoke it, simulate it, experience it. But the futures we attend to and “experience” in advance are inevitably just a tiny subset of the range of all possibilities. As we move down the ladder and an abstract future notion is made concrete, thinkable and feelable, we lose contact with alternative possible instantiations, at

¹⁵ The original three terms we devised and used at *Emerge* were, from the top down, Subject, Story and Situation.

¹⁶ On rapid experiential futures pedagogy, see Candy (2013, 2014).

¹⁷ The nature of the historian’s task and that of the futurist are comparable, in terms of “compress[ing] time and space into digestible narrative representations, so that patterns over time may be inferred and apprehended that would not otherwise be seen” (Candy, 2010). The tension between particularisation and generalisation described by historian John Lewis Gaddis as being at the heart of the historian’s narrative-making exists also for the futurist.

least for the time being. The future that can be experienced is not the true future – but we must create these artificially concrete contexts for thought and feeling in order to bridge the experiential gulf between the physical present and abstract spaces of possibility.

6. Conclusion: Towards an experiential turn in futures

In traditional futures practice abstraction is clearly favoured, and high-level scenarios often lack a sense of the human, 1:1 scale. Yet there are urgent and decisive reasons for bringing futures out of the realm of cognitive abstraction and into experience; into the body (Candy, 2010; p. 77–89).

The persistence of an experiential gulf in foresight work is arguably one of the main reasons for what we would say has been the field's insufficient impact on mainstream thinking about the future over the past half-century. Grounding forethought in both material and emotional reality very much increases its potential impact on thought and behaviour. Making futures practice experiential makes it more effective (Candy, 2010; p. 61–117).

However, experiential practice brings challenges both theoretical and practical. A theoretical challenge is that to manifest a future world means discarding lots of possibilities in favour of the one(s) ultimately presented: The Setting ultimately adopted will, naturally, be just one of many possible settings that one might choose. Within a chosen Setting, the particular Scenario is one of many possibilities. And in turn, the Situation brought to life is also one of many possibilities that could exist within the chosen Scenario. The art of it lies in selecting for attention and concrete evocation a future setting, scenario and situation worth thinking about. (Although this will be a line of argument to develop properly on another occasion, it is worth flagging that a lack of selectivity in this area may be where a good amount of current future-oriented design work falls short.) Each step towards concreteness is both a choice and an imaginative leap. Many questions about that world must be answered which the abstraction of a high-level scenario can happily gloss over, and the things populating it have to be visualised and manifested tangibly. Broadly, this is why working this way stands to bring something valuable to the field; because it requires a more detailed, textural, and felt engagement with the possibility space.

Practical challenges of 'turning experiential' for futurists include finding ways to translate or articulate the established, routinised foresight outputs with which we are traditionally comfortable – talky workshops, scenario documents – into an extended range of forms with which still too few futurists are professionally familiar at this time (filmmaking, theatre, and the design disciplines, for starters). It means becoming transmedia producers as well as the transdisciplinary thinkers that we already try to be. This in turn entails not only participating in, but likely often facilitating, collaboration across even more diverse skillsets, and broaching new boundaries – such as those between the expressive/narrative arts and analytical scholarship – in addition to the disciplinary siloes which the field already habitually challenges.¹⁸

If this is true, then a central challenge, perhaps indeed the central challenge, for the next generation of foresight practitioners will have less to do with generating and broadcasting ideas about the future, than it will have to do with *designing circumstances or situations in which the collective intelligence and imagination of a community can come forth*. To design and stage an experience of the future is one class of activity. To attend to the design of processes whereby such experiences are designed – making structures of participation – is another.¹⁹

Enabling group thought and creative processes has already been an important part of the futures field for years (Jungk & Mullert, 1987; Dator, 1993), and the stakes may be obvious to many already, but the affordances of group creativity and cognition using an experientially augmented toolset, and the details of what works best in what circumstances, are only now beginning to be worked out.

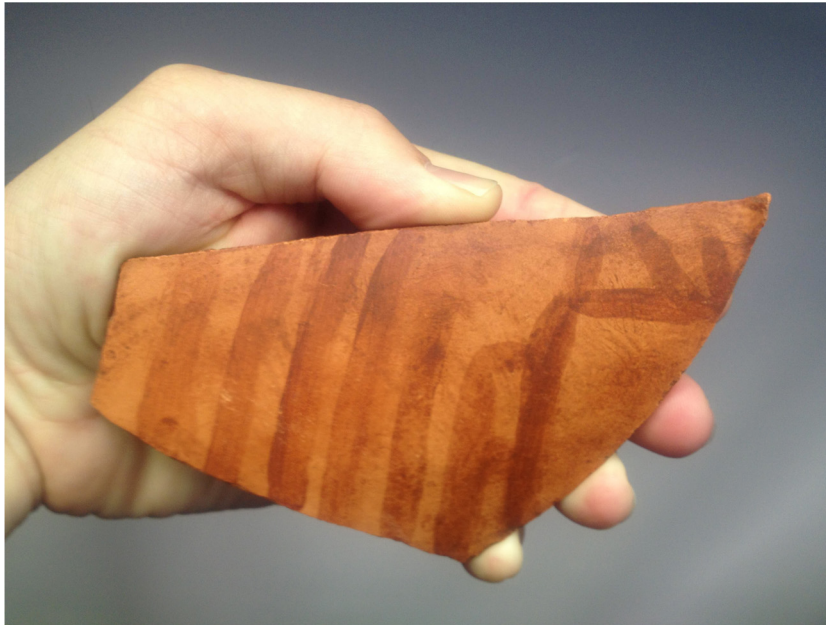
It is for the audience to decide whether the “monumental performance” described here was as interesting and instructive an experience as its creators intended. (Anecdotally, reactions from attendees indicated that our playful archaeological moment had variously amused, surprised and alarmed audience members.) However, the more significant aspect of this experiment, we suspect, was the way that a provisional and flexible structure of participation let around 20 people co-create a transmedia experiential scenario from scratch in two days. The creation of effective frameworks for group futures/design practice is an area ripe for further investigation.²⁰

¹⁸ See Ramos (2006), for an earlier articulation of this line of argument. Almost a decade of hybrid design and futures work can be regarded as a decisive turn in the field towards meeting this challenge.

¹⁹ New York University's Dr Natalie Jeremijenko often frames her hybrid practice at the intersection of engineering and the arts as being about the creation of “structures of participation”. http://steinhardt.nyu.edu/faculty_bios/view/Natalie_Jeremijenko This wonderful phrase resonates with and highlights both the constructivist episteme and designery aesthetic appropriate to contemporary foresight practice.

²⁰ For a recent case study of a framework for co-creating fragments of alternative futures, see Candy (2015). Note also the growing oeuvre of New York-based design collective The Extrapolation Factory.

The emergence of experiential futures, together with design fiction (and several cognate practices), and the communities around these, heralds a maturation of both the design and futures fields towards a dialogue with and embrace of each other's traditional priorities. We may hope that the descendants of these initial trials will be as imaginative as they are rigorous; as aesthetic as they are practical; and as fun as all get-out to make – as well as to experience.^{21,22}



[Image - Pottery shard from *The People Who Vanished*.²² Multiple shards were hand-crafted by workshop participant Trish Yasolsky and given to other participants as souvenirs.]

The creation of experiential futures requires some clarification of basic terms, practices, roles, and outcomes in order for a community of theorists and practitioners to be able properly to converse, exchange and collectively improve the work. Finally, then, here we offer a few suggestions for core skills and sensibilities that would need to be developed.

In order to become a good experiential futurist, you should²³:

- Become a student of the history, culture, and present situation of the places and people with whom you are co-creating – in order to empathise with and build upon their knowledge and experience.
- Become a perceptive mindreader – in order to understand the mental models of participants or audiences, and then decide how to expand or challenge those models.
- Become a flexible thinker with the habit of long-zooming and scale-toggling – in order to venture, with your transdisciplinary readiness to roam, wherever the inquiry may need to go.
- Become a master of situations – in order to facilitate the co-creative processes of groups, which includes recognising what to nail down, what to leave open, and when and how to improvise changes in response to the needs of the moment.
- Become an engineer of experiences, bridging the gap between the ground of present sensation and islands of abstract possibility – in order to be prepared to use whatever it takes to catalyse heightened creativity, thoughtfulness, engagement, and action, in yourself and others.
- Become a fastidious documentarian – in order to capture the materials, feedback, and insights created during what is a singular, often ephemeral, experience.
- Become a willing collaborator with those you meet along the way – in order to be poised to join forces with those who have skills that you don't, since no social foresight can be accomplished alone.

²¹ To frame this development with reference to the “integral futures”; experiential futures could be regarded as the *performative integration* of the long-neglected interior or subjective dimensions, in contrast to integral's intellectual gesture toward same.

²² Reinforcing the sense of collective ownership of the story we were telling, on the Friday one of our participants proposed creating some ‘ancient’ pottery shards painted with the glyph. With the same speed and gusto that had enlivened the proceedings since the start, participant Trish Yasolsky made and delivered these tangible souvenirs to our group and the event's organisers on Saturday morning. This added flourish serves to highlight the ‘extensible’ transmedia quality of the framework that had been established: once we all knew the world we were working within, additional media could be incorporated based on the interests, skillsets and available time of the participants.

²³ The tremendous influence of Jim Dator on this part, and in general, is gratefully acknowledged. See the section titled “To Be A Good Futurist” in [Dator \(1996\)](#). Our list means to supplement rather than replace that one.

The outcome of all this is not simply to create interesting experiences; it is to make experiences that lead to the creation of better futures. To catalyse better futures is “the work” we futurists are called to do, and being willing to recognise the shortcomings of our existing conventions, as these become apparent, and to evolve towards new horizons in how we operate and cooperate – just as we urge and aspire to help our clients, audiences, students, and other constituencies to do – is a critical part of that duty.

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